

DISASTROUS FIRE

MAIN BUILDING OF ROGER WILLIAMS GOES UP IN SMOKE. DURING PRAYER MEETING

Students for a Moment Victims of a Panic, but Are Gotten Under Control and No Lives Are Lost During the Excitement.

Roger Williams University, one of the largest schools for negroes in the South, was practically destroyed by fire Tuesday night, and the portion not burned was so badly damaged that it will be practically worthless.

The fire started in the garret near the center of the main building just as the regular evening prayer-meeting began at 7 o'clock, and in a few minutes the entire roof was in flames. The 225 students attending the school, about eighty of whom were girls, had assembled on the fourth floor of the building, and at the first alarm a fearful stampede occurred, and it was remarkable that all escaped without serious injury. The screams of the girls and the calls for help by the 140 boys was distinctly heard all over West End.

The Nashville fire department was called, but the college being out of the city limits, only the chemical engine and Engine Company No. 7 responded. Fire Chief Rozetta was one of the first arrivals, and although the engine company had 900 feet of hose, there was no water in reach and practically nothing could be done. The chemical engine and the twelve firemen did splendid work in saving a portion of the building and preventing the spread of the fire to other buildings in the campus, but were unable to at any time check the raging flames in the main building.

PRESIDENT ON HAND.

President P. B. Guernsey was one of the first members of the faculty to arrive at the scene and soon had the students under control, and under his command a good portion of the furniture was thrown from the building. While a great deal of the furniture was taken out it was practically destroyed by being thrown several flights to the ground.

With no hope of saving the main building, the fire department and the students gave all their time to saving the girls' dormitory, which was nothing more than a wing of the main building. By opening the front doors and windows of this wing a strong draft drew through the building and kept the fire from entering. This, together with the efforts of the firemen, who cut the woodwork from doors and windows, saved the wing.

Though feeble from age and just recovering from an attack of cold, Dr. Alfred Owen, Secretary and Treasurer of the university, did good work in keeping the students under control and preserving property. The fire was practically under control by 11 o'clock.

FISK STUDENT HURT.

Ed Randall, a student at Fisk University, who was assisting in taking out furniture, was frightened by falling debris and ran off the stairway and hurt his face. He was not seriously injured.

According to President Guernsey, the loss to the university was about \$60,000 and to individuals about \$8,000. The university losses were covered by insurance, but Dr. Guernsey did not know the amount, as the insurance was cared for in New York City. The individual losses consisted principally of libraries and wearing apparel. Of these Prof. Walden was the heaviest loser, he having lost his entire library of scientific works, valued at about \$6,000. Prof. Smith also lost a portion of his private library, and many of the students and other professors lost a part of their effects.

Nearly 200 people were left without shelter, but many residents in that part of the city and many from the down-town districts offered assistance and shelter was found for all. Most of the girls were kept at the residences of the officers of the institution, and the boys were cared for at the near-by residences.

OWNERSHIP OF PROPERTY.

The university is under the direct control of a Board of Trustees and Officers in Nashville, but these are subject to a New York Board, the grounds and buildings being the property of the American Baptist Home Mission Society. The institution was founded in 1866.

President Guernsey stated that he could not state what the Board would do about rebuilding or just what course would be pursued. "I think we will be able to continue the girls' department as before," he said, "but we will have no way to continue the boys' department until buildings can be secured. It may be that we will not rebuild on the present property, for we have had some magnificent offers for the property, and if the insurance is not sufficient to rebuild it is possible that we will sell and build in some other place."